lifestyle insisting his boss ate ‘simple dishes, macaroni and ham’, for example, and was ‘interested in animal documentaries’.

Herzog added: ‘Every morning he drank the juice of a whole lemon to protect himself from the flu. He insisted on Langnese honey for breakfast, liked soluble Nescafé and preferred to drink DAB beer from the can at the end of the day.’ Honecker gave a similar account: ‘Every morning I ate two rolls with butter and honey. At midday, we were at the Central Committee where I ate either grilled sausage with mashed potato, macaroni with bacon or goulash, and in the evening, I ate at home, watched some television and went to bed.’ Another titbit, as provided by Herzog was his boss’s hatred of fish and game as well as asparagus and mushrooms. He also refused to eat fruit or desserts.8

While he may have genuinely disliked Wandlitz, there is no doubt, however, he loved the fresh air and peace. Then there were the early morning visits from Erica Steinhorst, a physiotherapist who provided a massage and shared breakfast with him. Every fourth Tuesday, a platinum blonde beautician arrived to administer a manicure and pedicure, making sure Honecker’s hands were soft and supple.

He was not a big lover of physical activity and avoided the gym, preferring instead to stretch out on a deckchair or take gentle walks in the forest with Sonja, who was turning into a spunky, opinionated child. The Honeckers were loving parents – there can be no doubt that the couple adored their daughter and she loved them back, ardently. On weekend visits (she lived at a school dormitory during the week), Sonja would regale her father with tales from school. He never forgot her being teased by classmates because Walter Ulbricht travelled in such a big car. ‘She answered,’ Honecker recounted, ‘by asking ironically, “Should he travel on a tricycle then?”’ Unlike some of the distracted SED-leadership fathers, Honecker was attentive and cheerful with his daughter’s friends when they sometimes visited, playing board games, and asking them about their lives. Another significant part of family life was vacations in resort areas of northern Germany, Poland and the Harz Mountains. The Honeckers spent time on the north coast every year from 1957 to 1960 and from 1962 to 1984, where Erich enjoyed motorboats, curative baths, entertaining guests and,